

Every Day Since I Left Indiana

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Self-Uprooting

12 poems

Labyrinth

Every day since I left Indiana
 and slept naked in the woods
 and ate only stale pasta
 and sweated out all my impurities in the attic
 and gazed at the open endless night time sky
 so vast I forgot my feet were on pavement
 outside the little library
 where I read a moss-eaten *Grapes of Wrath*
 on a moss-eaten couch
 taking my stoic engagement in a moss-eaten lineage
 of paranoid seekers stumbling 'round a labyrinth
 I've bowed daily to nothing at all

In the labyrinth
 you're supposed to get lost
 and get okay with it
 then find your way to some epiphany
 but in the center was only a small wooden gnome
 winking
 I couldn't bow to it so I tore through the soleil
 trends broken through crystalline time
 shatters ceaseless dreaming ubiquitous mine,
 mine

Crashed out onto pavement again
 I got in my car and drove through America
 16 hours curtains closing on another somebody I left

bye.

Back home there was a flashing and everything got burnt up
 Now I bow my head to only everything everywhere
 I licked up the ashes.

In my cave in the Himalayas
solitude ruptures my past and present
from every throne and eulogy
and every delegation
this blazen idea beckons

Every day since I left Indiana
I flee further and further from a homemade myth

Neglected labyrinth, I am found
I bow to Thee everywhere

Radiant One.

The Golden Eggshell

Every decision oft-times turns my head to watch for the normal police:
I duck into my backpack and its contents are an irredeemable history,
not only declarations of identity, but sticky pieces of tape and gum.

Why don't you trade nothing for nothing? shouts the man who has all the fun.
Isn't it nothing for nothing and everything's won?

Retaliation of an impossibly demanding repertoire cradles this backpack like a baby
and tends to all its needs, further instilling familial fixation on a single
perishable
object.

You don't need to lose the backpack, you just need to drop the baby on its head.

The normal police fire calls to arms, and beat their drums
and shake the nerves in your toes to defend a yoke.

Yoke defends yoke. Dare you nurse them?
Return to pouring contents of misinformation above and below, like
engine oil in the shower.

Don't buy yourself anything for congratulations. Just keep doing good things and avoid evil orbs.
Their angelic pulsing, final
austere
luminous.

Only a candle flame to the vastness of totality which is preceded by, surely
the dropping of the baby, and its surrounding chaos, in other words,
the daily dying-into-yourself sends shockwaves through your many-lived bones
which hammer away at the golden eggshell of eternity:

Macrocosmically, the sky.
Microcosmically, the backpack.

See what sits between your legs on the train? And how it grounds you?

It keeps you earthbound. What did it say in the *Imitation of Christ*?

To despise the world
 in like, a cool, healthy, balanced way, yea, seek ye
 the orb of reality, cool
 healthy
 balanced.

The vastness of totality within and
 beyond everything,
 see it's all set in twos which
 becomes ones which
 becomes nones:

Content, Empty, Bedtime.

All devotion unfolding in recursive storytelling, and my own angel-death-birth scene
 the Baptism.

Almost A Haiku

I was going home after work and thought I can't waste this precious time so I turned on to Shadow Lake Road and found this stunning patch of brown pine needles

I jumped right in and we looked so beautiful there together and that is where I had what they call an experience, like this:

Glimpse of eternity
Divine Mother
Grant me eternal salvation
On soft pine needles

it was almost a haiku, then

I woke up
Divinity still tingling my mortal flesh
Directly above
Infinity merging with my finite self
I become the sky
I am the sun shining on my
still closed eyes

2 Names

Jackie moved to China at 21 and stayed 21 years until her husband who came from a cave dwelling family left her and the kids for his 21 y/o lover.

I fibbed some of those numbers, by the way.

A thought I just had, standing outside the car, finishing off a smoke: *I love being trans and smoking cigarettes.*

For context, at the show, Zeke's shirts were \$20 if you're trans, \$25 if you're cishet. I gave them \$23.

Hanging out in the kitchen at the Rat's Den watching Chaser Bait's set all these freaks and weirdos making the whole rest of the world seem queer I notice that I am where I've always wanted to be, here, we long-haired conspirators holding this quiet candle flame secret.

Jackie said the resistance is forming itself and maybe she's right, though I hesitate to entertain grand thoughts of revolution and systematic upturnings maybe this candle flame *will* become a bonfire and burn this old world down and maybe we really *will* be holding hands through the nightmare & come out pure and in love and without borders between our bodies and our earth.

See, being trans is a socio-political revolution. I learned this only when I started using they/them pronouns and wearing a skirt and singing like a school girl, and not before.

Of course, you hide the war plans from the adversary, and talk in codes and share secrets,
giggling burning secrets,
not simple desire-play
but all-encompassing and childlike. *Everything's really in everything, no really, it is!*

Bodies and identity and the earth and struggle and solidarity, radical change, earth-shattering rebellion, yes, a total complete upturning like Ella said, I have two names.

2 names:

One, an old, given name. Home-base body identification. How it ought to be, the devil says, gravity, the great glue sustaining creation, habitual illusion, upheld by dignity and history and pride and our parents and their parent's suffering. This is how God divided the water from the sky so we may stand on solid earth and glance around and spend our lifetimes proving our given names like good children.

2 names:

One, an old given name, a material name, with material rewards for your material compliance.

The second name is given, too, but you have to claim it. You must seek it though it cannot be found within the firmament. You must despair for it though it is hidden to all emotion. You must make it your life's work, though it has nothing to do with your life.

It's like we're all wearing space suits with our unique name tags proudly displayed and when we take off the helmets we'd lose oxygen and die but recognize each other in that final moment. Dying is okay! If I may recognize you for just a moment, I'd die daily.

Putting on a skirt is taking off the helmet, I've killed the old name and breathe my home planet's air for the first time. Dead-name, dead-name James, dead-poet James, dead-anything James.

2 names:

One, an old given name, slain by my yearning! And a new name, eternally revived by my care and self criticisms, mine, my own, untainted by earthly habits or narratives or star-formations, material bondage is forever slain, I cut all chains with the sword of discriminative will power.

I love being trans and smoking cigarettes. See what I mean?

Scribble

1000 toxic traits upon an imprinted mellow sky red barn drive, flashing open oak in arrogant recollection what's to sing about, introspection? when intros have been fumigated inspected under the magnifying glass and left to burn exacerbating mutant pasts, clarinet rings sharp bright in the cloudless bank of non-being nothing left to summer over or suffer

Hangs heavy under empty rotted hallway stained ceiling cigarette crayons drawing out and in aimlessly and nothing comes of it meaningless cause I'm sidelined by Spirit, my Grace intuitively passing out cold in another unfinished basement four walls of noise and I, desecrated in this poetry

I, desecrated at last an unfinished assemblage of all my past foundation kicked and rotted sense-slaves succumb to hopeless scurrying and panting to pile structure onto rubble would they ever finish the pyramid?

It stretches all the way to heaven

Snot Poem

I could use the
littlest piece of tissue
to clean up the littlest bit of
snot in my left nostril
but my big hands
grabs the biggest sheet
and cleans up only mostly air

that little snot
overcomes itself
in the trash can

(my meek hands dwindle in comparison)

Self-Uprooting

I've been given the tools to clear the
land and dig myself deep into the Earth
and the patience to watch my roots grow
strong and weathered

But everytime I lie down in the soil it's
like trying to go to sleep with my feet
sticking out from under the blankets

Shoveling the dirt over my head feels wonderful
until I start itching and sprouting and
some vital part of me shoots out like
a zombie's hand and pulls me from the grave

It seems
I am helplessly addicted to self-uprooting.

Planting a seed and ripping it out of the
Earth a day or two later
like a little kid's science experiment
Teacher says give it time
and little kid pouts but listens
 I pout but drop out of college
 and tell everyone in town that I've found
 a magic bean stalk which will carry us all up to heaven.

(Occasionally, I say this with conviction)
 And by the way,
 You can tell I am lying by the smoke that
 escapes a clenched grin
 and in my nihilist fingers,
 The loose swagger of self-deprecation
 stubbing it out in disgust

Overconfidence is a signal of my emaciated ego
And nothing hurts better than burn-out

That's why I make my bed in the morning
and change into warm clothes at night
and pray I wake up somehow different

That's why, when I gaze up at the priest
from underneath the floorboards I forget
which one of us is on acid. Because,
Self-uprooting is a double-blind study between
myself now and myself three seconds ago

And I know a journalist in Boston who says
the commitment will pay for our indulgences
down the line.

250 Year Cycles

I'm sitting at 11am
 staff meeting, and I
 suddenly realize
 (Ok, not metaphorically,
 I mean really) the
 head of the table
 is piloting above an
 astral battlefield.
 So deeply invested in
 (what I have no
 opinions about), but is
 oozing in vibration
 and dripping onto
 the (I think, reasonably
 sized due to each
 and every soul's
 individualized impossibility) - what,
 a battlefield?
 So, dripping or
 otherwise 'sorbing
 itself between the
 pores of a semi-
 permeable membrane,
 pilot's view,
 this local being
 may really be international
 making serious waves
 ¶ in the time-space
 continuum. Good
 poetry admits
 its mistakes -
 take 20 steps
 back: ¶ evolution
 of consciousness
 and unity of all
 mankind.

See, I
have been praying
for this (I mean,
really)
See, I have
learned. In the
fire-rite of
self immolating technique
burning-desires turned ash
white smoke admonishes
the seeds of the
earth; breath-wind
clarity arises.

250 years later,
if the staff
meeting goes well,
the empire will have
crumbled, or have
been crumbled, but
who saved our
suppliant souls?
Was it the meeting
director? I truly
don't know! Maybe
Bob Dylan knowed.

♦ A good
poet stops asking
question
and spilling all
the plans.

Captivation

I dropped off a note for the cellist in the marble dungeon of Grand Central Station. It said, "You got IT!" because it felt like he had it, at least for a moment. It was more obvious in the faces of the crowd, who were almost drooling in their captivation. The cellist, however, noticed me scrawling on the scrap of paper, debating how best to gently express what I really felt like doing, whooping and hollering *O Hallelujah Sweet Lord* and shouting this is IT! This is IT! Can't you see him go? Heartbroken, absorbed, all of it came across his sullen bow, his mourning fingers. I decided on what to say (knowing, of course, that it could never convey anything. Talking about *it* is like dancing about architecture, if you know what I mean). I dropped the folded note into the open cello case like a bandit. It fell alongside a few scattered dollars and a printout of a QR code. It landed gracefully. So I

turned and skipped away like
a deer on the roadside to track
18, back north again, back to my own
drunken captivation...

Butterfly Kisses

Take me to the place where we would plant butterfly
kisses on each other's lips like the little kids we are
burning holes through our ocean skin
 never quite understanding why we rejoiced when
 the bright flame licked up any sense of meaning

How our heavy feet made the world reverberate with
every slow step on unnamed streets
 and dissolve completely on sloping dunes

And when we buried ourselves in sand from head to toe
 the waves,
 with snow-white uniqueness, ever-changing
 but still waves all the same,
 would lull us gently to sleep

Take me to the place where snakes writhe hidden
beneath our checkered protection
on which we lie unaware,
 tugging on shining blades of grass

Where our lazy fingers would draw random lines in the Earth
 and we would scream every obscenity that found itself parasite to our bleeding tongues

Never questioning this unobserved will
Never wondering just how far down the water
reached under our outstretched, paddling arms

Take me to the place where everything we touch turns to flame
 And kiss me as we douse ourselves in gasoline

The Guts Of It All

In making good and bad go away
judgment ceases and eternity opens
like at the gates of the cemetery
amid golden lights showcasing
a dead one

Flower's sacrifice is wilting
to a name that is forgotten
by me, right after I read it
I don't remember, I just listen
it passes right through me

A bird comes down and pecks at the seeds
scattered underneath the tombstone
and at the open mic
it's here only once and forever
Elliott is playing "Don't Think Twice It's All Right"
& I hear the guts of it all

*Ain't no use in calling out my name, gal
Cause I can't hear you anymore...*

Can You Leave Eternity?

Can you leave eternity?
I think you can for
a moment

Sunset remains
looking over your shoulder
on the walk to the car

Then, driving by lights of town like an animal driven by starlight the erotic red hue is burning
into and
through
me

words
fall short 94 million
miles into a single
observation of poignancy

Does sunset have a heart to break?

If it did I wouldn't
be so alone, so my eyes
stay on the road

Because if I crashed
I'd become another ant to
flick off the stalks of
swaying cattails

See the cattails
and their breathing,
in and out golden ether

What I'm trying to say
is this

Shape of
eyes, slowly blinking
shut and opening to
some flicker of divinity

I could be 60,
then 23. If the way
I carry my head high
through the grocery store
stays steady, and
occasionally

a glance out the window.

Thanksgiving

9 poems

Hollow Bamboo

Met Jacob in Toronto at the Dock Ellis No No Room put his rep on the line and his ego too checked in today about if his Uncle Andrew at Rough Trade got in touch with us yet took quite a risk in my own interests this energetic pragmatist reminded me of Django or a traveler maybe I met at a train station in Delhi and maybe he would've done a Puja ceremony in the river with such candor and grace all the locals would gather to sit and clean his feet, you think he 'members me?

soft glow of firelight from within the cave

Now waiting for an email from Andrew we dream of unbridled possibilities and ceremonial ash expanding and also possibilities of my own happiness as life unfolds curiously, exactly as I want it to, churn the soil of Cosmic Laughter bubbling behind every experience and act-i-(on) the ocean of bliss which I dance as one with Cosmic Mother, Beloved, *I have been listening to the hymns of creation* and singing your name quietly within wherever I go Jai O Baghwan Jai O Baghwan Jai O Cosmic Beloved! I think what really helped was meeting other seekers at the Greenwich temple and bowing to each other with real actual reverence. This was an uncaused causation of my own personal commitment to rebellion (honesty) - *I Can Talk To Spirits* note how I say this with a giggle.

See all these layers of mind-stuff appropriating the present moment as if they have any right to the peaceful shores of my solitude?

I spit and kick and cast off occupier-mind
Your flag is false, O little ego in me!
See the stoic pride of my native stillness?
Perfectly calm in the face of all invaders
I plant my roots in the soils of Infinity.

“Here I am, Joy is claimed mine forever!”

I proclaim this to Jacob hoping he 'members, like this: big grin and all laughing cause I noticed whenever I open my mouth and ask if we're here everyone detracts a little, I think Cosmic Baby is shy, that's all. The more you talk the less you know! But I know I know nothing, they call me the Cosmic Charlatan I use spiritual deception and trickery to attain my goals, like last night early morning she looks deep into my eyes and says let me just admire you for a moment,

I look at her and see wilting flowers.

She also says, you intrigue me, Sweet One, the way you think and I say I am hollow bamboo
and she kisses me, the conman, me, nobody in a space suit, how else can I tell her?

I remember the way her eyes gently rolled back
like she's seeing the whole of creation all laid out right there between the darkness
of a skull and the warm lamplight and throughout there's the white noise drone we put on
to drown out our sex-scramblings and I am drowning in her arms,
she thinks,
but in my mind I am merging with the sound of *Aummmmmmm*
set to a 3-hour loop on Spotify, night lover, are we the same?

"I'll love you forever, I'm just that interesting!"

You intrigue me and you waited a year to have me, at least that's what you told the muse at Dock
Ellis, a behavioral psychologist who reminded me of my old therapist, who owns a 3-year period
of my life by the way, now she's back with a vengeance whispering into your ear and spilling all
the secrets exactly how to have me,

Here's how, just take it, I am hollow bamboo.

After she told the therapist she told me, whispered it into my ear with my hands pinned on the
bed behind my shoulders I've wanted you for a year and I just smiled and honesty would have
been saying the same thing but that would be like showing off a plagiarism, weird and a little
gross see, we don't want honesty,

We want fun!

We want perpetual story-telling,

How fascinated we are with the oblong and the occult!

How fascinated we are with all the wanting, the wanting!

No, I don't need to hit your vape, damn it I want to! Anyways,

I gave up the virgin planned-purity party for more story-telling material. I'll keep these stacks of
paper neatly filed for a little while, and when I burn them in a devotional setting sooner or later,
the ashes will scatter and maybe please this shy, goofy universe.

See, I am categorically unregistered. I dip my toe in the rushing waters of finite existence
but only a toe. You, drowning,
I keep you separate with my poetry.

Teach me, O God, how to pull ourselves out of the river?

I've Seen You In Soil

Outside of my church the people run free
From structures that bind personality
Running and rampant they search for a clue
But nothing is sacred inside of the shoe
Which kicks out at pigeons that block off the street
In hordes of feathers that stink of oil
“Do you know my name?” desperate cries from the feet
Pigeon replies, “I’ve seen you in soil
Twisting and turning and feeding on clay
Forever resisting the bright light of day,”
But people are people and worms are worms
There’s plenty of toys to distract from the urge
For the infinite bliss that awaits all who may
In earnest proclivity glance up at the sun
And shrivel to nothing, oh isn’t it fun?
When nothing is nothing and everything’s won

Outside of my church the people lay ruined
But a bird is a bird and a human is human

Thanksgiving

I am the son of America, the old idea
the successor of colonial violence and racism that continues
to pillage and raze all that is good and
sacred in this world
all that is left out of range of
my ancestor's swords
it is Thanksgiving and we still celebrate
this national day of mourning
by joyfully stuffing ourselves with
more and more self-preserving symbology,
dead animals, and empty gratitude
this feast, like the blood of all
the innocents who once called this place
home, will never satiate the demands
of generationally perpetuated devastation
I love my family
and today I am grateful to share
a peaceful meal and each other's company
out of reach of the deafening warplanes
and carpet bombs decimating neighborhoods in Gaza
entire families and bloodlines
mine is safe around the fire in
America, the old idea
Let this whole thing shatter.

Bird Is So Busy

Bird is so busy only existing in such a state as devoid of unnecessary brilliance yet a total prerequisite like color in a 1,000 piece puzzle to the non-compassing portrait of my vision. The murky surface, unknowingly green, mirrors like a funhouse. *Total fantasy*. Bird now disappearing (the games never cease) other senses diminish the bounded eye, and I can hear EDM reverberating a car maybe two blocks down on

Neon corner

Street corner pageantry

but still the green two-way is ever rising.

While neon corner

Or rather, everything there ever was, is, or will be minus neon corner
exudes light

Stolen for your sins from the constantly dwindling pre-conceived notion of what dusk should look like.

Just check out.

In deep solitude, one-sided voice of forgiveness pours deeply into itself with tremendous steel ladle, upheaves the churning definer, soup of the pointer finger, that I know anything at all!

Concepts morals morels and definition

fade dutifully into the places between non-being and being.

Well I get itchy just singing the songs of the birds and showing off my wings like they do. I get silly, holding the door open for Mind At Large
seep through this hand of hands
and entice me with fragile grace.

3 Nights, A Horse

3 nights, a horse
Face first in the mud
Paisana says,
"On your feet"
A felled horse, and shotgun
The earth shakes under pine trees
Kids wipe the slate clean
Bring me to Madrid, where they speak Russian
In large glass hotels and sip cognac
And dream
And the planes never come searing overhead
How many before have chosen a hill
A hill of all places, to die on?
3 nights, a horse
Face first in the mud

Another Poem About The Moon

I used to write *such* good poetry
 when I was in love and inspired and alive
 but now I am happy and dull and I can no longer squeeze out every drop
 of raw emotion from some lonely scene
 like the full moon above the beach at night in November
 when it's cold and the pebbles I skip across the gentle lapping waves expand into larger and
 larger circles, fading paradoxically as their influence grows
 into which I stare intently, not out of fascination but more so out of trepidation to break this gaze
 and glance up at the pale eye above me, pulsating with such a heavy reality.
 I know it will tear me up and leave me unwound and stumbling
 & bleary-eyed in the parking lot.

No, it's not like that anymore.

Instead I write about how waves and weather
 and websites are all made up of the same stuff
 And me, too.
 I'm part of this world and the omniscient light that pours out of the moon
 is the same that reflects off my eyes from the computer screen
 and that powerless feeling has become my pedestal.

Here, I stand

on the countless bodies of my past who have all been massacred by an exploitation of meaning
 and misadventures into the void.
 Playing with impermanence like fire
 I keep on lighting myself up and even now,
 I can see a new form being born from ashes.
 born and raised and born and raised until finally
 I begin to experiment with describing the thing that cannot be named
 (what a friend of mine called the darkness surrounding a flame)
 Or, the part of me that doesn't change
 when the moon creeps into my life again
 and tears down everything I built
 out of passion.

South Tekanic Highway

From what I remember, it's driving alone in the dark, and the car's weak headlights, just a flashlight in the cave, reveal the presence of mountains ahead and to the sides. The road is curving through post-reality, where mountains are blotted out by a conspiracy of clouds and by the planet's positioning. No stars, no moon. No parents or Gods. Just my weak headlights to serve as a reminder, every so often, that there lie dominant forces just beyond my vision. Not that the unseen mountains are threatening, just that I am small and how delicate it is.

I am an unbalanced force speeding
in the night

The mountains are.

I stand in opposition to a presence which knows itself even in complete darkness. I think I know
myself only in relation
and in withdrawal

as fleeting memory.

Tunnel

Some things I noticed include a hesitancy to write in pen - not for the permanence of it but because it bleeds through to the back of the page; my soft bated breath heroically resisting the howling winds at the lookout on Skyline Drive - not knowing enough to declare independence from my habits but meaning to every time cigarette smoke dries up my throat so I can't breathe right the rest of the day - instead choosing to smoke only at night for the quick amnesia; I'm forgiven and gratified come morning - and my lungs are a yellow-stained hallway in the lobby of a motel somewhere far away where I throw open the windows and my bags on the bed and open my arms wide and shout Home, Sweet Home! for all the parking lot to hear it.

I noticed inspiration spikes and pitfalls and spikes in pitfalls. Should I leap right over or in or gently lower myself down? Playing the tape in my car (it was a perfect record of Richmond and DC, the nights with Ted and Grace, Jake, Anna, Jay but I only learned their names saying heart-felt goodbyes on the patio in a light rain) so I must have made a choice one way or another. Ted invited me to Spain. We talked about dreams and adventures and couldn't admit we were in one. You just can't admit that.

I made plans by doing nothing. Watch it fall into place and give up entirely. I noticed how beautiful the whole thing is and fell in love with everyone again, if it wasn't obvious.

Did you know John, the guy selling Sonrisa's merch is friends with Cortez, and Pepper too? He was an old Yarga-head, of course, just like Cortez was young in Hartford and I might be young too but it sure doesn't feel like it. I feel like a piece of tape holding up a hand-drawn show flyer by the mantle in VSC from 2014. I can feel a blurry face see me wilting and reach up to rub me real hard back into place. Back straight and really stickin' now, unnamed heads outside to rejoin the decades old mingle of leather jackets, pins and punk memorabilia. I might switch places with a piece of brown glass poking out from under the stairs, or maybe one of the hundreds of cigarette butts in the concrete receptacle; flipped on its side and expanded it becomes a hollow, pitch-black cylinder stretching two miles to the other side of the mountain. Just a couple yards in Paw Paw tunnel I could only see my feet in a little puddle, and the infrequent but comforting drip of runoff tracing the hard, loose shale to rejoin the Chesapeake & Ohio Canal. The stream is nearly still, silent, and out of sight. I took a few more steps then ran back to the door-shaped light - deep breath of relief in the open sky, I crushed my can and headed back to the campsite.

Later, half-asleep in my car I learned to tell the time by the angle of moonlight on the little pond at Greg's farm, Shenandoah, Virginia. There was a tornado warning in the valley that night and Greg said, "Keep an eye to the sky, not much of a shelter in my barn but you ought to be okay. Mountains protect us here pretty good," which they did. They protected, served, and inspired. They created that funnel of wind I was talking about, that harsh whip in my face leaning over the

edge. They created a boulder-cradle which rocked me to sleep like a parent loves a baby - I was all three. Now adolescent eating cherry pie in Rudy's Diner we asked the waitress what's happening in town. She said, "In Shenandoah, don't blink and you'll miss everything."

We blinked and missed it all anyway as the scenery shifted to Lina's place, a cozy little farm where a great white Pyrenees bear-dog named Aspen led us to a soft patch of grass to rest our heads that night. We set up camp, Aspen tagging along, maintaining that calm, graceful air of an experienced farm dog. Grateful for the company, we pet and played with and tackled that dog till the sun stooped below the mountains and we sped off to Charlottesville again. It was "Curtis on Tour" at UVA's Old Cabell Hall - a round chamber with wide, open ceilings and a golden organ adorning the walls - with the legendary Jason Vieaux on guitar and Robert Díaz on viola, alongside two unnamed women in matching red dress to round out the quartet. A replica of Raphael's "School of Athens" dominated the theater's back wall. Zach pointed out Pythagoras and Socrates. I counted 17 slack-jawed sleepers in the crowd of old and balding dignitaries getting their hit for the evening during the second movement of Paganini's "Quartet in A minor." Before the piece Díaz explained everything & I have to be honest, it ruined my night. See my double-standards? A writer is a con-man, don't forget it.

Hesitancy put aside, it was time to get active. "Let's go ride the mini truck," Jack said with certainty. If there's one person in the world I can trust with my life to rip through Washington's every stop sign while I'm bouncing around in the pickup - it's Jack. And he floored it, I mean really pushed that tiny truck through the winding black streets and the empty ownerless fields and the empty manicured fields behind lit-up empty mansions - and away from all that, once more in the dark tunnel of night and into the star-shaped passageway,

right through to eternity.

Centipede

Hello, centipede
You are the whole creation
Can God be condensed?

Hello, Myself

11 poems

I Am Ocean Mind

I am ocean mind
sprouting from the cerebrum
calm lazy naptime

I'm grapefruit slices
in the warm sun, India
by Master's cottage

He is just inside
writing, pausing, head bowed in
reverence, writing

I see him through the
window, and a little me
in the reflection

if I squint my eyes
I bow to the windowpane
& it starts to grow

larger and larger
right in front of little me
it's a house swelling

heaving with ideas
pulsing & lo! it shatters!
Out floods his wisdom

& it pours over
land & mixes with the sea
everything rising

& gushing, spinning.
Remember - have you been caught
in a crashing wave?

in shallow waters?
by the edge of the ocean
it grabs you tumbling

& bubbling, your limbs
flip inside out & under
& gasping for breath

Once upon a time
this happened to little me
The wave tore my shorts

down to my ankles
& I woke dazed on the sand
naked & breathless

& alive and there
I noted the taste of the
cosmos in my throat

At the hermitage
it poured itself into me
Not the wave of life

with its chaotic
heaving, forceful at the brink
disoriented

nakedness, not that
It poured into me like the
ecstasy of sleep

in the summer shade
of an oak tree, head on moss
pillow & complete

annihilation
of identification
with the fragile skin

birds chirping peaceful
& nowhere to go but here
in summer-dream-land

peace, exposition
denouement, curtains closing
all of it in form

Remember - glancing
up in the movie theater
watching spherical

beams of light that make
all the pictures, trying to
trace beginningless?

you can't crane your neck
so look back at the movie
and THERE! it gets you

The house is only
a house again, the guru
is only writing

pausing and bowing
his head in deep reverence
tapping his pencil

and little myself
just a reflection, revealed
in the windowpane

Garden Universe

This Garden Universe, Lotus Land of Buddha,
stretches vast before behind and all 'round

Gaze 'pon infinite expansion, training
mind-vessel: Star captain, I am -
Time begins electric throttle sputters glistening
life-force condensations on the glass boundary
of my skull-helmet

Thoughts are twinkling actual planets
contained raw energy manifests
Bulging, throbbing. Guide mind-vessel
through energy systems trace wisps of
light with my fingertips buzzing intoxicated
and burning self-fulfilling fulfillment
unite my fate with powers of love and will
To be free burns Self perpetual

Guide mind-vessel nowhere faster and deeper
and deeper within. Nightly meditation: Star- travel God-communion. O, Dreamer!
I put pencil to paper to bring Spirit to thought
to muscle to words to praise Thee and
Thine eternal Word. From Spirit to Spirit,
Home-empty nothing-bliss void to manifestation

(Keep rowing that love-boat on home,
when you're done you will know)

In Paradise

In paradise we plucked food from the trees
And we say, God gave this fruit
On Earth we work to sustain ourselves
And toil in fields, and cook every day
And clean up the kitchen
And we say
We did it all by ourselves.

In bondage to the world
The Wheel of Law is
Set in motion
And the stars forever display our fate
But consecrated action outwits the stars
And the bonds of action are no more.

We toil in fields, and cook every day
And clean up the kitchen
We chop wood and carry water and say, Thy
Will be done O Lord
On Earth as it is in Heaven.

Mother

Mother is the playing field of creation
Mother is space
Mother is environment
Mother is winking at me in all the stars in the silent night sky
Mother provides everything, she is the infinite gift
Mother chastises gently, if you ask for it
Mother tells me to clean my room and get on with it
and pick up trash on the sidewalk and be kind to everything
Playing in her garden as little ego-baby, I watch as Mother tends to all creation
Perfectly at peace under her watchful eye, nothing can ever hurt me.
Maybe I will pick some pretty flowers, and wrap them neatly in twine, and offer it to Her,
I watch in reverence as she lifts the bundle to her nose and inhales deep and a gentle breeze of
serene delight smell of earth, dirt, life in everything
wafts over me,
life in the breeze and
sky and air and emptiness
emptiness everywhere.
Mother is space.
I am hollow bamboo.

Father

I am already liberated
I have wrote every poem.
I am as close as I am
to God right now as I
ever will be.
I hear the coyotes howling
at the full
October moon, just beyond
the edge of the forest.

In my heart-cave
I am howling too.
Father, can you hear me
at the edge of creation?

I Saw Two Ravens

I saw two ravens
between twin mountains
in blue, empty space
flying like brushstrokes.

Above was the ground
below was the sky
and right now, the water is calm.

An insect lands on the moon
gently ruffling eternity, and nearby
birds are singing a sad song.

I take off my hat,
empty my pockets and offer the contents
to Mother Nature, for now.

I kick off my boots
and wrap myself tighter in the shawl.

Crouched down by the pond,
consciousness expands
and I will leave it at that.

Hello, Myself

Indifference and reverence are
one and the same.
Glancing over my shoulder
at the setting sun,
I am In-amored
with the sound of
my boots crunching snow
and how it reverberates through my toes.
I sit down in the warmth surrounded by leather
& become myself
and giggle. Cosmic Author
and I, subjective infinitely
and infinitely subject, trace fingertips
(ecstasy, definitely, for a second)
then vow to a century of celibacy.

Patience is indifference and reverence
in awe of an astounded aphorism
just out of reach.

A Line Or So About God

A line or so about God
and hanging my head upside
down on the park bench
to see a crescent moon
through the trees
working out a verse
about writing this down
in the dark and giving
something up to something
else.

I broke off into conversation
and struggle to
recapture the theme:
*You can see the dark
parts of the moon too*
like, leaving it all
up to God
or rather, passing off
all responsibility for my
handwriting.

For example
how my faith was
stronger in the dark
picking up a phrase
or two like antique
jewelry
measuring, thinking,
casting it off.

Or,
wandering around the
forest humming,
& unable to
conceptualize footsteps.

Meaning dissolves in the light.

Absorb / Absolve

Absorb form into essence
then absolve
uniqueness merges into the pure white light
Buddha sits patiently on a golden throne
of mind unperturbed by changing
mirrors
and unraveled by perfect compassionate
loathing of mortality and all this,
shimmering mirage.
In shimmering mirage
I see sunlight touching the dead
leaves outside the tent where my
friends are sleeping.
Unobstructed from its source
94 million miles away
infinity reflected in my finite vision
and in the Earth finally absolved
I wonder if I'm the same?

My Offering

Well, my God has visited me
O, my God has visited me

This world is made of love
This world is made of love

My God has visited me
and told me it's all made of love

By His grace it shall all unfold
By His grace it all unfolds

Because my God has visited me
and shown me the 10,000 beautiful
and 10,000 awful visions.

Because one hundred million billion
lives have been bundled up in
one karmic offering garlanded
with roses and
because I presented this one
and all its tarnished virginity
to my Lord on a moonlit night:

I waded into the lake
and came out of the shadows of the forest
and like Moses lifted a snake
I lifted my spine straight
and said come into me, Father
Mother, Light
come into me for my life is yours
and cuz I left all my other
desires back at the campsite.

Even the desire that a child should
live
when Thy will has called him back
to the Cosmic Bosom.

And I heard the puppet mother cry
And I heard the puppet mother cry

And I was so sure there had
been a death on a
moonlit night.

But I had already buried
the bird,
debts paid with life.

I returned to the campsite
carrying the sorrow of every
mother
“Is the kid alright?”

And the cosmic mother
Spun fire all the while.

Wheel Of Fortune

How does one get home reliably fast?
 is a line on an advertisement on the train.
 What is all the rush and fuss?
 I wonder on my seat on the train.
 We will all, of course, get home reliably
 as fast as God can fit 1,000,000
 elephants through a needle. Huzzah!

Freedom is here because it will be!
Eternity is now only! These lines
 I would display if the choice was mine.
 Wait, are we going anywhere?
 I went and got everything I ever wanted
 and then I forgot why I wanted all that.
 Wait, there's a new smores lava cake at Domino's
 and now nothing actualizes my desires.
 Cuz I have all the lava cakes in
 the universe and I own the Domino's
 and also all the money in the world.

Grant me prosperity on this island of gold
 Gimme some water to drink while I'm drowning. See? Sea?

See I got this will from the higher ups
 in the postal service and I
 willed myself into a creeping vine.
 There it is outside train window
 and on 6th and Grand,
 growing and dying and
 a couple inches at a time
 if well-trained the elephants are,
 the creeping vine climbs.

Sooner or sooner or
Sooner or later or later or
Sooner or later or later
(Really, I have no preferences)

Verily I say unto Thee
I'm almost done, yippee!